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On Re/Imagination: Against the Phallogocentric Memory of the Wars' Names

“If, in a good war story, war makes you a man, does rape make you a woman?...
Look away. The other side does it, not us” – *Viet Thanh Nguyen*, “On True War Stories”

“We complete the details left to be forged. In the end, we compose [Achilles'] shield”
– *Paisley Rekdal*, “Memory, Time, and Elegy”

Within the vast array, models and methods of story-telling reside a complex question of ethicality and aesthetic: [we], the readers and voices of many nations, are tasked with finding ‘meaning’ amidst the personal, public, and private interests of the Wars’ narratives. I question, what is it that [we] hold as a *singular* Truth, especially when [we] are aware that some of the truest ruins are remembered, yet never inscribed? While looking towards the creative forms erected to memorialize the impressions of the War, [we] must critically examine the various significance of imaginative, symbolic, and real constructed narratives regarding life and of loss. Under the scope of post-modern American expressionism, the condition of a “True War Story” has taken shape through nationalistic interpretations imbued with geopolitical, ideological, and identitarian poetics. Through this essay, I argue that the Wars’ narratives survive under the guise of phallogocentric artifices subsisting from antiquity. Classical authors such as Homer, Aesop, and Ovid – the foundations to the elegiac form of honor, valor, and victory – uphold the nation’s significance of story-telling; that is, unless [we] re/imagine the state of individual and collective memory as survival through poetic fragmentation and the plurality of interpretations. I explore the various depths of ‘meaning’ found at the intersections of both *passive* and *active* memory,

specifically the ways in which [we] remember the identity of oneself and others, before, during, and after the Wars' stories.

As you may have observed, my selected language recognizes the Wars' as a multifaceted story of emotion and expression. This perspective is informed by the insights of academic and creative author Viet Thanh Nguyen, who serves as a guiding influence in this paper's exploration into the survival of ethics and aesthetics. In his 2013 publication titled "Just Memory: War and the Ethics of Remembrance," Nguyen delves into the contradictory aspects of naming and memorializing the Wars, describing them all as experiencing an "identity crisis" due to the uncertainty and malleability of recognition and commemoration (4). This utilization of 'lack-of-naming' acknowledges plurality of the individual and collective relations to the Wars' narratives, and addresses the inherent ambiguity, or absence thereof, in memory and memorialization. With this essay, I aim to bring many interdisciplinary artists and authors alike to re/imagine the various expressions of remembering that have become, or have always been, engendered by phallogocentric poetics that systematically value the nationalized identity of honor, valor, and victory. It is due time to confront the creative forms in which [we] remember how all of those touched by the War have become "torn apart as one sector of society is set upon another under ['masculine'] dictatorship," as historicized models and methods of recognition and incorporation teeter "between muteness and fragmentary speech" (Friedman 303). Through this re/imagination located within the margins of fragmentation, [we] the readers and voices of many nations, can transform and subvert the act of recognition with intergenerational and transnational story-telling using the language[s] and poetics that subsume the hegemonic signification of 'meaning.' By employing multiple models and methods of story-telling, [we] can emphasize the significance of a "dialectic unity of 'opposites'" that resides in the often fragmented, semiotic

expressions of memory (Hu, 10). This unity extends across various dichotomies, such as the public or private, individual or collective, as the memorialization of the Wars' are highly susceptible to political and moral inscriptions fixed in phallogocentric understanding. With the view of the "unity of 'opposites,'" one can come to reckon with the ambiguity of memory and memorial, and acknowledge the fragmentation of the mother/land, mother/tongue, and re/production of experience as guised by phallogocentrism. By re/imagining the 'meaning' of fragmented memories described in "True War Stories," [we] can transcend the names of the Wars' and remember beyond the "dull hum of the [violent] machine we live in, the white noise of a massive mechanism oiled by banalities, bolted together by triviality, and enabled by passive consent" (V. T. Nguyen, "On True War Stories").

The Phallus and the Poetics

The prevailing, and commonly regarded as "successful," representations of memory or memorial, as per the Wars' literature (and the attached political and moral significance) produced and demanded in the United States, are profoundly influenced by what deconstructionist Jacques Derrida termed 'phallogocentrism.' This neologism establishes the framework of my analysis as it blends the two terms – phallocentrism and logocentrism – underscoring the strength of poetic language, and recognizing the indelible fragmentation of memory under gendered-dyadism, such as the mother/land and mother/tongue, as well as the re/production of intergenerational and historicized 'meaning.' The first term, phallocentrism, refers to the centralization of the 'phallus' in the creation of meaning in terms of relation and recognition: the 'masculine values' that 'accompany' this physical member become enmeshed into the formation of experience and memory, and are therefore, privileged in the consideration of nationalized memorial. Derrida's blend of the latter, logocentrism, adds another dimension to this. The logos is a prevailing

Western notion formulated from the selfsame Greek term that denotes the ‘word of Truth.’ Under various structures, this word has elicited various interpretations since antiquity, particularly within Stoic philosophy as the “Seminal Reason” in which all things came to be, then ordered, and returned. The intersections found in the nomenclature and language, similar to that of the classic lyric poetry, that engender the function of banality, rationalization, and justification of the epistemological conceptions of the Wars’ memorial, result in a permissively narrow, yet governing knowledge of poetic imagination that overvalues the ‘masculine’ merits of identity.

In the context of locational production and demand, the United States has historically presented various forms of memorial regarding the Wars’ narratives that, more often than not, follow this privileged and extremely narrow line of phallogocentric ‘meaning.’ Under this context, the creative expression of a “True War Story” is then confined to similar depictions of the epic-canonical theme of (Greek) *nostos*, the hero’s return to the home/land, originating from the Wars’ narrative and [his] inextricable identity formation (Friedman 434). Both the *Odyssey* and the *Iliad* are rich with expressions of *nostos*, as exemplified by Achilles’ contemplation in Homer’s *Iliad*. Here, Achilles ponders the enduring legacy of his memory, encompassing both the individual and collective dimensions. He grapples with the dichotomy between the public memorial erected physically, politically, or morally, in his honor, versus the continuation of life. The chosen language of the father/land reflects the dyadic process of social relation to a gendered attribution of ‘value’ in regard to his recognition of himself and his nation: “If I stay here and fight, I’ll never return home, But my glory will be undying forever. If I return home to my dear fatherland My glory is lost but my life will be long” (9.425-28). Although many believe Homeric texts to be anachronistic, it is remarkable to observe the resonating parallels between the name, location, and language, all of which significantly contribute to the individual and

collective identity within the poetic identity of the Wars' stories [we] carry. I turn my attention to the widely acclaimed 1990 novel, *The Things They Carried*, which portrays the experiences of young American men drafted into the Vietnam War¹ and dialecticates this intricate process of phallogocentric merit to 'meaning.' In the novel's opening pages, veteran and novelist Tim O'Brien receives thirty-seven remarks of praise and endorsement, then succeeded by his twenty-two short stories that blur the lines of imagination, symbolism, and reality in a War characterized by ambiguity, moral complexity, and the burdens of memory. The themes of order, meaning, and return to an ethical remembering confront the ways in which story-telling carries a legacy of phallogocentric repatriation. One of the stories, "Speaking of Courage," follows the re/imagined story of life and loss of Norman Bowker, a fictional name for one, and many real men, who return to [their] home/land:

"How'd you like to hear about the war?" he might have asked, but the place could only blink and shrug. It had no memory, therefore no guilt...And a pity about his father, who had his own war and now preferred silence. Still, there was so much to say" (137, 141).

Tim O'Brien's re/imagination of the life and loss of Norman Bowker emphasizes the possibility of individual emotion and expression to reckon with the collective memory by exposing the national injustices perpetuated by the silencing weights of the Wars' stories: his work of fiction operates as a double-entendre in the phallogocentrism of "True War Stories." In the superseding chapters, O'Brien's imagination actively *others* the 'enemy' through the use of location and language, as understood through the post-modern American expressionism, by

¹ The usage of "Vietnam War" versus "American War" signifies the naming-processes in which [we] locate the recall of the Wars' stories, whether it be individual or collective. My usage of this noun is to align with Tim O'Brien's interpretations of the War, as he depicts his later-in-life 'return' to Vietnam with his daughter, stating that "the place was at peace"(173), emphasizing the political and moral mythifications attached to the creative imagination of home/land in memory.

utilizing the political and moral mythification of the Wars' narratives to further dis/place and dis/possess the land in which was 'once' a battleground: "the countryside itself seemed spooky...the land was haunted. We were fighting forces that did not obey the laws of 20th century science...it was a ghost country" (O'Brien 192). It is with this excerpt that I wish to highlight the construction of the phallogocentric identity tethered to the nations' re/interpretations, and utilized through differentials of the 'other' to create meaning and value under geopolitical, ideological, and identitarian poetics. As articulated in the breath-taking novel *On Earth We're Briefly Gorgeous* by American poet and essayist Ocean Vuong, there exists no inherent law that governs; rather, it is solely the laws of gravity that ground us to the Earth (Vuong 135). Here, powerful forces of passive and active memory, whether public or private, compel us to experience the emotions and expressions of the lives buried beneath its surface; or, those who reside elsewhere, not granted inhumation, those lost in more than one form. Vuong is a leading author in the realm of poetic re/imagination as he depicts the deep intergenerational binds of memory, highlighting the intricacies of remembering each other through the stories [we] tell to stay "one step ahead of life" (197). Through such story-telling, ambitious through the authenticity of memories' instability, it is the future who revisits the past (8), and therefore, [we] must work with diligence to poetically re/imagine life and loss with ethical remembrance, while ultimately, attaching plural aesthetics of transnational solidarity to tell our stories.

Sociologist Maurice Halbwachs defines collective memory as a discursive ground "where individual memories are made possible by memories already inherited from the communities to which we belong...which is to say that we remember through others" (qtd. in V.T. "Just Memory" 10). Understanding the facades of the Wars' story-telling, particularly the uncertainty and malleability of recognition and commemoration engendered by phallogocentric

artifices enduring from antiquity, can foster a plural remembrance of fragmented poetics, thereby disrupting the “complex feedback loop within the social imaginary” (Kim 255). This prompts me to question how the subversion may start: where does the ethics of remembrance originate for those who are not named, remembered, but never inscribed, or outright *othered* under the scope of nationalistic interpretations that are contaminated with geopolitical, ideological, and identitarian poetics? Within the discursive creation of post-modern identity, memory, and expressionism, does the “True War Story,” entrenched in the semiotic and linguistic conventions of masculinity, retain its integrity when confronted with dis/placement, dis/possession, and dis/comfort (K. Nguyen 436)?

The Ethicality of Memory

American psychiatrist Judith Lewis Herman was a breakthrough name in the field of academic trauma studies, specifically following the American Psychiatric Association's 1980 term and categorization of traumatic events and the reactionary expressions of the Wars' [masculine] veterans. Herman posited that medicalized narratives, rooted in phallogocentric understandings of honor, valor, and victory, attributed to the socialized 'meaning' of remembrance, yet also narrowly defined the emotion and expression for masculine heroics. Her 1992 publication, *Trauma and Recovery*, opens with demands of plurality that spread across 336 printed pages, detailing the various forms in which [we] remember and forget the emotions and expressions of the haunted. She contends that the remembrance of the reality of horrific events is essential for both restoring societal order and for the healing of individual memories (Herman 1). Yet, the ethical and aesthetic dimensions of memory emerge prominently as [we] confront both the individual and collective Truths embedded within the Wars' stories, alongside the recognition that under the phallogocentric narrative, the most profound ruins are not written down” (Vuong,

175). If, as Viet Thanh Nguyen suggests, the Wars' touch and transform "everything and everybody, including, most of all, civilians" ("On True War Stories"), how do [we] reckon with the discrepancies between the individual and collective, private and public memorial?

This is to suggest a concept provided by the feminist philosopher, Margaret Urban Walker, who contends that the *ethics of responsibility* is constantly under examination and negotiation. It describes the contexts in which the Human is to be "held responsible in certain ways, or [is] exempted or excluded from responsibility of certain types or for certain people" (qtd. in Sawin 176). Walker's model communicates an expressive and collaborative method of ethical action that flows seamlessly into questioning of poetic re/imagination situated in epistemological transformation that disrupts and reckons with the politics of recognition and incorporation. I attach Viet Thanh Nguyen's diligence with the *ethics of remembrance*, a very similar concept to the aforementioned negotiations of responsibility that focuses on the relationship between passive and/or active remembering and forgetting. In terms of the individual and the collective memory of the Wars' narratives, V.T. Nguyen addresses the contradicting and totalizing tendency to "imagine one's [own] memory as whole or to forget altogether, [which is also] too often the case in any nationalist imagination" ("Speak of the Dead, Speak of Viet Nam" 30). To combine these intersectional perspectives on ethical action is to generate a plural understanding of the experiences held by the post-modern identity of emotion and expression, the individual and collective life of the nation ("Just Memory" 9). The subversion of the dominating phallogocentric notions of 'meaning' can prevent [us] from "being immobilized by an inevitable ambiguity" of a non-singular story (Sawin 176). Through these provided models of interpretation, further inquiry into the Wars' stories that depict "the *other* as different from self," (i.e., with the Name and the nation) can generate epistemological

transformation in poetic re/imagination, “[allowing] us to reach new ethical, aesthetic, and political ground” with acknowledgment and recognition (Schutte 48). To decenter the self from the experiences of difference is to see oneself as an individual *within* the collective memory: it is to become conscious of the selective and dyadic process of dis/placement, dis/possession, and dis/comfort that arises from the plural emotions and expressions regarding the Wars’ stories.

The Erection of Memorials

If the collective memory serves as a discursive space where [we] remember through others, how does the poetic imagination of private and public memory intersect with the Western phallogocentrism that values “its worship of the monotheistic, phallic, authoritative, and singular work, the unique and perfect name” (Haraway 55)? I look at Maya Lin’s *Vietnam Veterans Memorial*, constructed in 1982 on the National Mall in Washington, D.C., as a primary example of creative re/imagination that borders on the margins of the phallogocentric narrative, yet also acts as a metamorphic form, subsumed by the nationalist image of masculine merit. At the time of its dedication, the Wall² inscribed 57,939 names of the Americans’ dead: Lin, according to her handwritten proposal for the memorial, fashioned these names in a ‘chronological order,’ with “the names [wrapping] back to the origin, where the date of the last death is carved, at the bottom of this wall. Thus the war’s beginning and end meet; the war is ‘complete,’ coming full circle, yet broken by the earth” (Lin) At just twenty-one years old, Lin’s conceptions for this memorial reflect the various understandings and interpretations of the Wars’ stories: the names of the soldiers become repetitive and non-contemplative, yet linearized within the Wartimes’ uncertainty, and given visual recognition with a quantifiable loss of American life. The location

² Owing to the tireless dedication of countless hours to identification efforts, the Wall hosts a website known as the “Wall of Faces,” which offers images to the identities inscribed upon the granite. Detailed information, including the date of casualty, date of birth, home of record, and panel/line position for these individuals can be accessed at <https://www.vvmf.org/Wall-of-Faces/>.

of ‘the Wall that Heals,’ as it breaks and breathes into the landscape of the Washington D.C. National Mall tells an endless-story of “homecoming” and “conclusivity,” one that is ultimately built on uneven foundations of home/land and Western imperialistic possession, and begs the question, what is it [we] feel with “the sensation of the world split open, of things falling apart,” and where is it [we] find solidarity (Friedman 284)? On her self-titled studio website, Maya Lin explains her purpose and meaning behind the repetition of nomenclature identifying the lives lost: “We, the living, are brought to a concrete realization of these deaths....[It is a memorial] for personal reflection and private reckoning” (Lin). In later discussion with Lin, excerpted from *American Studies* by American critic and essayist Louis Menand, the two address the ambiguity of the Wall’s aesthetic, Menand stating that the memorial brings about a silent moment of remembrance in the polished granite where “you look into the underground, where the dead are buried, and you see, behind their names, the ghost of your face” (Menand). I ask if [we] come to see the fragmentation of experience through the inscription of numerous names, as it is not the ghosts of one’s own face in which [we] must reckon with: there is nothing concrete about the identity embodied by the names of [our] dead. The ambiguous nature of remembering the Wars’ stories cannot be inscribed by an imaginary or symbolic mythification of a united front of national heroism. The singular, yet collective, listing of lives of [our] dead, even as displayed with poetics on a smooth partition, becomes subsumed by ideological, moral, or political considerations, and in the end, if we continue to reproduce the singular narrative, the majority of our Stories will go untold in the Land of the Free for the Few.

This act of reflecting through the ‘ghosts of one’s face’ connects directly to the phallogocentric recognition within “True War Stories,” as Menand and Lin also discuss the addition of Frederick Hart’s 1984 “representational sculpture,” the *Three Soldiers Statue*. These

forms depict “larger-than-life servicemen” that gaze upon the Wall: three forms of embodied memorial that represent the masculine, honorable, valorant, and ‘victorious’ American dead; even though “the [original design] competition guidelines stipulated that the monument ‘make no political statement regarding war and its conduct’” (Menand). American poet Paisley Rekdal suggests that the proximity of Lin’s Wall and its corrective addition of Hart’s flagpole and statue act as a “gesture of inclusion set against a backdrop of exclusion” (Rekdal 100). The memorials – even if communicated under the original intention of post-modern recognition as a public and private location for remembering have become embedded in “imaginative investment, projection, and creation” (K. Nguyen 443) that is procured in the canonical narrative of phallogocentric understandings of the inscribed name and nation. In the end, it is the dominating archaic identity that directs the creative emotion and expression of the Wars’ individual and collective memories, ensnared by geopolitical relations. This is not an ethical act of remembering, regardless of the aesthetic form: by pluralizing the use of poetic re/imagination [we] can come to disrupt the industrialized memorial and the acts of passive and active forgetting those who are not named, remembered but never inscribed, or *othered* under the scope of the nation’s phallogocentrism.

On the literary front of poetic imagination, Paisley Rekdal makes connections to British poet Alice Oswald's 2011 elegiac publication, *Memorial: A Version of Homer’s Iliad*. The re/imagination of the classical text is described by the author and analyst as a “‘history of leaves’ written by other leaves” (Oswald qtd. in Rekdal 110). I draw from Rekdal’s focus on the [phallogocentric] poetic language and her interpretations of insufficiency. She communes “the spectacle of loss, the fragmentary and incomplete lives of men [we] can name but never entirely identify” (108). With these examples, I suggest, like many before me, that the “unique and perfect name” to remember ‘the War’ is insufficient, as it does not exist: the many identities of

the individual and collective imagination are susceptible to moral and political mythification, where the names of the dead are utilized to urge nationalistic thought of ‘homecoming’ embedded in masculine traditions of recognition while concomitantly *othering* the enemy, the living, and the lost. Rekdal concludes that many North American public memorials are constructed with haste and desire of “national [moral] self-aggrandizement at the expense of [political and] historical accuracy” (106). I continue to extend her ideas further with Viet Thanh Nguyen’s understanding of Paul Ricoeur’s *ethical remembering of War*, and insist that the “success” of literature regarding “True War Stories” functions similarly to memorials that reckon private and public remembering. In attempting to homogenize the ‘honor, valor, or victory’ of a “True War Story,” [we] find that the various forms of imaginary or symbolic expressionism call for citizens to remember the nation’s heroes and dead, which becomes a much simpler process when urged to forget the enemy and *their* dead (“Just Memory” 11). Maybe, due to the archaic phallogocentric merit and the poetics subsumed by irrational systems, “that’s why Americans welcome home their soldiers without wanting to think too much about what they might have done *over there*” (“On True War Stories”).

On Subverting the Phallogocentric Imagination

My claims here do not assert that [we] remove all memorials from the ‘meanings’ that they have bestowed to both individual and collective memory throughout varying times, places, or nations. Indeed, “memory cannot be eternally preserved or recovered,” but the Wars’ do *not* become “increasingly meaningless to the generations of descendants coming to them anew” (Rekdal 111-12), for the violent language and action of displacement and dispossession of the War is nothing new. There is an inevitable ambiguity of non-singular interpretations of expression and emotion, for [we] are always-already a part of a memory machine, whether it in

our own minds or alongside the collective remembrance of the Wars' stories. The names, locations, and languages to which [we] attribute 'meaning' under the guise of Truth *must* be disrupted by inverting the phallogocentric, because "there is no mother tongue, only a power takeover by a dominant language within a political multiplicity" (Deleuze and Guattari 7). Moreover, the deeply entrenched foundation of identity, inexorably intertwined with archaic notions of nationalism, has had a deleterious effect on the ethical remembrance of the Wars' past and present that twin into one (Rekdal 99). To subvert the dominant phallogocentric poetic is to re/imagine "the power of speaking the unspeakable" and reckon with the creative energies that are realized and "released when the barriers of denial and repression are lifted" (Herman 2). The individual and collective memory remember through the recognition of varying identities in which [we] carry, but [we] are not defined by a singular name that merits the 'meaning' guised under false-narratives of honor, valor, and victory. Poetic re/imagination declares space for epistemological transformation where [we] come to recognize and reckon with the ambiguity of story-telling, specifically about "True War Stories." The "Seminal Reason" for which the Wars' nationalistic narratives continue to be produced and demanded as Truth, is evidenced through varying emotions and expressions of geopolitical, ideological, and identitarian poetics that dis/place and dis/possess the "ruin[s] no one can point to. A ruin without location, like a language" (Vuong 175). By subverting the phallogocentric individual and collective memory – yet approaching and remembering the past as a precondition to the "new" (Friedman 285) – [we] can search for 'meaning' within our Wars' stories that will forever and always hold plural interpretations of emotion and expression, never allowing any individual or collective to "disappear into [this] country's amnesiac fog" (United, CPH). If it is not "names, seemingly infinite in number" (U.S. DoD) that convinces the individual and the collective of the ambitious

nature of the Wars' story-telling, then let it be the fragmented emotion and expressionism that might mean nothing, "but you have it now" (Vuong 184). Susan Stanford Friedman, a distinguished narrative theorist, former Professor Emerita, and chairman of the English department, as well as founding member of the University of Wisconsin-Madison's Women's Studies Program, succinctly captures the phallogocentric sentiment in her words:

"[the] dislocation and return that engenders an imaginative search for a homeland of the spirit, one in which the body of the poet and its analogue—the body of the nation and its people—are no longer sites of humiliation, abjection, self-loathing, shame, and violation. History, tradition, and memory are central constituents of "making it new," of making the body whole, of envisioning a future not just for the individual rebel but for the self as a member of a diasporic community" (308).

In conclusion, it is imperative that We recognize the inherent ambiguity and disparity within the stories We carry, each imbued with its own relational essence, many of which remain uncommunicated due to the phallogocentric merit and uneven foundations of the nation's concept of home/land and language. The pursuit of Truth and 'meaning' is not uniformly applied nor conclusively achieved. Therefore, We must reckon with the reality that our understanding is shaped by the emotional and expressive nuances of poetic language and subvert the narrow politics of belonging through re/imagining the landscape in which [we] gravitate.

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